

LAPD robbery figures may be skewed

An uptick in statistics is driven largely by shoplifting incidents, records indicate.

By LIBOR JANY

At the Los Angeles Police Department's weekly crime briefings this fall, its leaders tracked what seemed to be a troubling rise in robberies in police divisions such as Southwest and Rampart. The numbers showed an increase in stickups — if only on paper.

Upon closer inspection, department records obtained by The Times indicate that most of the incidents may have started as shoplifting.

Under LAPD metrics, hundreds of thefts in which a suspect uses force or fear in the commission of a crime are counted as robberies — even if no weapons were used and no injuries occurred.

It's a common scenario: A shoplifter, arms full of merchandise they didn't pay for, makes a beeline for the exit, only to have their escape blocked by a security guard. A struggle ensues, and the thief knocks the guard over or merely threatens to do so, triggering a potential felony charge.

Through the first week of October, there were more than 1,200 such incidents across L.A., according to department statistics released through a public records request. This accounted for roughly 1 in 8 robberies, down slightly compared with the same period in 2023.

Some officials wonder whether the data reflect a shift by business owners toward more aggressive loss prevention strategies, leading to more in-store confrontations with security guards.

Faced with plunging profit margins, more companies — from mom-and-pop shops to big-box retailers such as Target — are making "stopping people at the threshold" a priority, said LAPD Deputy Chief [See Robberies, A6]

Islamic State's lasting ideology

Group's brutal philosophy still governs offshoots and inspires "lone wolves" to commit violence. **WORLD, A3**

A rose-colored end to season

The most prestigious of all the bowls should host the national title game, Sam Farmer writes. **SPORTS, B10**

Tesla reports declining sales

Analysts cite the lack of new models from the EV market leader amid rivals' increased offerings. **BUSINESS, A7**

Weather

Not as warm.
L.A. Basin: 67/47. **B6**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

Printed with soy inks on partially recycled paper.



POLICE and federal agents investigate the suspected terrorist attack Wednesday on Bourbon Street in New Orleans that killed 14 people.

Links sought in New Year's attacks



THE TESLA Cybertruck packed with fuel canisters and firework mortars is shown after an explosion early Wednesday outside the Trump hotel in Las Vegas.

Authorities say man who hit New Orleans revelers acted alone, but seek possible ties to Vegas blast

By HANNAH FRY, RICHARD WINTON AND SUMMER LIN

Federal authorities uncovered new details into the suspected terrorist attack in New Orleans that killed 14 people while probing possible links to a second New Year's Day incident in which a Tesla Cybertruck blew up outside a Trump hotel in Las Vegas.

The timing of both acts of violence, just hours apart, has drawn suspicion. Officials revealed both men in the attacks served for years in the U.S. military, including for a time at the same base. The two men also rented the vehicles used in

the attacks through Turo, a platform where people can rent cars directly from vehicle owners.

But federal investigators stressed it remains unclear whether there was any coordination or if the perpetrators knew each other.

"It's an interesting thing during these kinds of investigations that if these turned out to be simply similarities — very strange similarities to have — so we're not prepared to rule in or rule out anything at this point," Las Vegas Metropolitan Police [See Links, A10]

Initial snowpack outlook good

Survey shows promise, but La Niña could be just around the corner

By NOAH HAGGERTY

Every winter, scientists across California ascend high into the Eastern Sierra via skis, snowshoes, motorized snow cats and helicopters. Along with equipment to survive harsh days and nights in the backcountry, they bring a snow-sampling kit made up of long, thin aluminum pipes.

Their mission: measure the weight of the snow beneath their feet. The simple measurement has serious implications for the whole state. Come spring, it will make up nearly two-thirds of Los Angeles' water supply — an essential lifeline as Southern California continues to endure unseasonably dry conditions.

On Thursday, hydrologists made their first measurements of the season at Phillips Station, which the state has measured every winter for over 80 years to forecast L.A.'s water supply for the coming year.

This year, the team found a snowpack equivalent to 9 inches of water at the station. It's roughly 91% of the average snowpack at the station by this time of year and slightly behind the rest of the state, which is cur-



CALIFORNIA Department of Water Resources engineers conduct the first snow survey of the season Thursday to assess the state's future water supply.

Court strikes a blow to FCC

Appellate ruling says agency can't subject internet providers to greater regulation.

By MEG JAMES

A federal appeals court on Thursday dealt a blow to President Biden's Federal Communications Commission, striking down the agency's hard-fought and long-debated open internet rules.

The FCC had sought to reinstate a sweeping policy established under President Obama that was designed to treat internet service as an essential public service, similar to a water or power utility.

Under the so-called net neutrality rules, internet service providers would have been subjected to greater regulation. A Republican-led commission repealed the rules in 2017 during President-elect Donald Trump's first term.

Early last year, the FCC — then back under Demo-



Don't miss L.A.'s next big story.
Download the app for breaking news notifications.

